



“ Hemant Karkare got killed because he was wearing a substandard jacket. But even this has failed to deter corrupt officials.”

Y.P. SINGH, Former IPS officer

ONLY A HANDFUL OF CRPF MEN KILLED IN THE DANTEWADA ATTACK HAD BULLETPROOF JACKETS

technical trials and asked the nine vendors to resubmit samples. It delayed the delivery of the bulletproof jackets by another six months. In the second round of tests at the TBRL, only the samples presented by Kanpur-based armourer MKU and SM Carapace Armour passed. In April, the contract was awarded to the lowest bidder, MKU, which bid Rs 15,600 per jacket. Simultaneously, the CBI moved in on Anjani, charging the Guptas for the earlier case and seizing all the files related to the case.

Members of India's nascent body armouring trade allege this cartelisation was promoted by the DRDO itself when it set up the Centre for Technology Extension and Cooperation (C-TEC), an inhouse organisation for the transfer of technology to the private sector. Over a decade ago, the DRDO tied up with Anjani, MKU and Armadyne of Bangalore to supply BP jackets to the police and paramilitary forces in a public-private partnership. The jackets designed by the DRDO were manufactured by Anjani and MKU, and tested at the TBRL in conditions that competitors allege were less than transparent and meant to favour these three firms. “We always won-

dered why they chose these firms over the several others in the country,” says a senior Tata official, a key player in the body armour trade. The technology to manufacture such essential life-saving equipment was not transferred to any one of the 40 government-owned ordnance factories.

Over the years, Anjani and MKU, whose proprietors are related to each other, effectively cornered India's growing bulletproofing business. In an interview earlier this year, R.K. Gupta bragged at having secured every single MHA and army contract for bulletproof jackets in the past five years. The consortium continued to do business until around 2006 when C-TEC was wound up and the firms were left to do their own business. This was clearly going to be a sunrise sector given the huge demand and supply gaps in India's decades long fight against insurgency and terrorism. The MHA estimates the paramilitary forces have a shortfall of 87,121 jackets or an alarming 40 per cent shortage over a sanctioned total of 2.09 lakh jackets. The CRPF, which needs at least 40,000 jackets, is the worst-affected. The Indian Army is to

shortly float a tender to acquire 1.88 lakh bulletproof jackets for its soldiers. That's a market of nearly three lakh jackets in the next few years.

The flip side—bulletproofing is not exactly a high-technology sector. It features at the bottom rung of a protection spectrum topped by vehicular protection. The first indigenous bulletproof jackets were in fact designed and crafted for the paramilitary forces nearly two decades ago by an army officer, Major-General (retd) V.K. Datta, who used heavy steel plates lodged in a simple jacket. What is now high-tech is the synthetic bulletproofing fabric like Kevlar manufactured by just four global players and imported and fashioned into jackets by local manufacturers. And this is the reason why it is sometimes disparagingly referred to as the ‘tailoring trade’. Government officials point out that a number of players jumping into the fray and an unregulated business means that the jackets are now being sold as mere commodities instead of vital life-saving equipment.

A virtual lack of testing facilities mean private players can't test and certify their jackets. The TBRL is the sole testing facility in the country and is not open to private players or state police forces who want to test their jackets. It will take the home ministry another nine months to commission its proposed high-tech ballistic test range in Chandigarh. With such scams and cartels in operation, the efficacy of India's bulletproof jackets in protecting its soldiers will continue to remain in question. ■